

Message 1 of 37

RE: neighbors

Sender	jeff.king@enron.com
Recipients	[t.king3@prodigy.net]
File	king-j/sent_items/12.

Hey mom,

Thanks for the info on Stan. What are you guys doing for Thanksgiving? You guys are welcome to come here this weekend. I believe Janets flight leaves at 10 Saturday morning. We are just going to hang out anyway. Call me if you are coming. Bailey finally slept in her big girl bed! -----Original Message----- From: "Lauren King"

<t.king3@prodigy.net>@ENRON Sent: Wednesday, November 21, 2001 9:07 AM To: King, Jeff Subject: neighbors

Good morning to you. Sonny P. said they were in Houston this weekend because Stan/Staci had moved into a new house. I told him so did you. He sent this reply. Hope you have a good day and have a happy Thanksgiving tomorrow. I love you! Yo Mama. Yes, you have to make reservations when you go to Huntsville State Park.....its a very nice place.....we are staying here Thanksgiving...well, we are having a Hardee family reunion at the civic center in Poynor....Patti and family are here now....Stan moved near Beltway 8 and I10.....in the Spring Branch Memorial school district.....off Gessner....12330 Old Oaks St. You take the Toll Road Beltway 8 to the west and get off on I10 and and go towards the city and stay on the feeder road about 1/2 mile and get off on Gessner...and go about 4 blocks to Old Oaks. Sounds like its not too far from Jeff....they need to give each other a holler...Stans work number is 713-228-6601 and home number 713-467-6754. You might want to forward this to Jeff....if you do...then HI JEFF...bet you could not hit one as far as you did in Big Sandy that time...hahahhaa

Message 2 of 37

FW: True Quote Information

Sender	stanner@apbenergy.com
Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/inbox/14.

Thank you for your interest in the True Quote Energy Trading System. The platform can be accessed by using your Internet Explorer (version 5.00.39 or higher) and going to www.truequote.com <<http://www.truequote.com>> on the internet. While on the True Quote Homepage please take a few minutes to familiarize yourself with the action tabs that can provide excellent information for anyone in the energy trading industry such as: News - Including daily updates in our Nymex and Gas Storage reports and forecasts by our staff Meteorologist. Tutorial - An informative Flash demonstration on the use of True Quote. Contact Us - Email any questions you may have directly to our Client Service Department. System Overview - Learn about features that set True Quote apart from other systems. We have also attached an updated Users Guide that will walk you through [truequote.com](http://www.truequote.com)'s functionality.

We have generated and assigned you a specific User ID and Password listed below: USER ID jeffking PASSWORD bailey For security purposes we suggest you utilize the option we provide to change your password once you successfully access the system. If you have any questions regarding the system please feel free to call our Client Service Department at 800.327.1499. Trevor L. Atkins Project Manager True Quote, LLC Work (800) 327-1499 Direct (502)-212-4912 trevor.atkins@truequote.com

- truequote users guide 9-24.doc

Message 3 of 37

Mid-Year 2001 Performance Feedback

Sender	perfmgmt@enron.com
Recipients	['jeff.king@enron.com']
File	king-j/all_documents/14.

KING, JEFF N, ? The PEP system closes on Friday, May 25, 2001 ? Our records indicate that you have been requested to provide feedback on one or more Enron employees. The deadline for completing feedback is Friday, May 25th. ? Below is a list of feedback requests with a status of "OPEN". Please complete or decline these requests as soon as possible by logging into PEP at <http://pep.enron.com> and selecting Complete Feedback from the Main Menu. ? If you have any questions, please contact the PEP Help Desk at: Houston: 713-853-4777, Option 4 or email: perfmgmt@enron.com London: 44 207 783 4040, Option 4 or email: pep.enquiries@enron.com ? Thank you for your participation in this important process. ? Employee Name: LEWIS, JON THOMPSON, KERRI VALDERRAMA, LARRY

Message 4 of 37

Your Ameritrade Account (KMM8302655V16068L0KM)

Sender	starting@ameritrade.com
Recipients	['jeff.king@enron.com']
File	king-j/deleted_items/122.

Dear Mr. King:

Thank you for giving me the opportunity to assist you today. I have included the information to provide your network administrator in regards to your trouble with the Super StreamMachine.

Super StreamMachine uses a socket connection via the HTTP 1.0 protocol on port 80. Upon initial connectivity we utilize standard HTTP headers to initiate the login and response. It appears that there are certain caching engines that disallow this mechanism as they require all message packets to be HTTP 1.0 compliant. We do not send a full HTTP header on all messages and thus is being blocked by the cache engines. You would either have to be able to get to our server directly without being routed through the cache engine or the cache engine tuned to allow non HTTP packet checking after the initial connection is generated.

Here is the IP address for Super StreamMachine: 204.107.120.3. If your network administrator can check to see if this IP is being blocked by the cache server, this may be the answer to your problem.

If you have further concerns or inquiries, please reply to this message or call Client Services at (800) 669-3900 or (402) 970-5805.

Thank you for choosing Ameritrade!

Sincerely,

Josh Wells Client Services/Technology Support Ameritrade

Message 5 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- The Purpose of Crucibles

Sender	marketplace@lists.crosswalk.com
Recipients	['jeff.king@enron.com']
File	king-j/deleted_items/279.

T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

The Purpose of Crucibles

The crucible for silver and the furnace for gold, but the Lord tests the heart. - (Proverbs 17:3)

This proverb describes one of God's strangest mysteries. It is a description of God's formula to refine the human heart in order to bring out its finest qualities. The significant leaders who make the greatest mark for the Kingdom had to experience their own crucible and fire. Without it, the dross can never be removed from the human heart. Without it, the encumbrances weigh us down. God understands the human heart. He understands that for us to become all that He hopes for us, there are seasons of fire. Joseph went through many tests. Succeeding in the test qualified him for greater responsibility. The greater the use in the Kingdom the greater the crucible to prepare the right foundation. Some of God's greatest crucibles are found in the marketplace where we live every day: the employee who betrays our trust, the client who refuses to pay, the vendor who falls short of our expectations.

Each of these is God's tests to find out how we will respond. What tests are being brought your way today? His grace has been provided that we might pass the tests that He brings before us. Should we fail, we need not fear. His grace is sufficient for this as well. Ask God for the grace to walk with Him in whatever tests He has placed before you this day. He is able to accomplish what He wants for you.

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Message 6 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Thirsting After God

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Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/deleted_items/267.

T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Thirsting After God

..."Let me inherit a double portion of your spirit".... - (2 Kings 2:9)

The first requirement to move in greater power and authority in God is to hunger for it. Yet even this hunger is born from God. Elisha hungered after God. Elisha saw many miracles as Elijah's servant. But he wanted more. He wanted a double portion of Elijah's spirit. When he asked Elijah for this, the prophet responded, "You have asked a difficult thing." It wasn't because it couldn't be granted. Elijah knew that with great anointing came a great weight of responsibility and difficulty.

Second, humility comes before honor. Elisha was known as the "servant of Elijah." How would you like to be known as "the servant of John"? Your name is not even mentioned. This was the preparation of Elisha. It has been the preparation of many men of God. Consider Joseph, the servant of Pharaoh. Consider David, the servant of Saul.

Third, Elisha committed himself totally to his calling. The Scripture says when Elisha was called to join Elijah, the younger man left his farm business completely. He slaughtered his oxen and had a great feast for the community. It was all or nothing. He could not fall back on his farm trade if his new venture didn't work. This demonstrates Elisha's pioneer spirit in stepping out, not knowing what was ahead.

Do you want greater anointing in God? "You will seek Me and find Me when you seek Me with all your heart. I will be found by you" (Jer. 29:13-14a). Begin thirsting for God's anointing in your heart today. This is the starting place.

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Message 7 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Possessions of the Kingdom

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Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/deleted_items/125.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Possessions of the Kingdom

But I will punish the nation they serve as slaves, and afterward they will come out with great possessions. - (Genesis 15:14)

Whenever God brings you through a time of great adversity, you can expect to come out of that experience with great possessions, if you have been faithful through the trial. This is a universal truth. Wisdom comes from obedience, not knowledge. When we have been tested and proven, the reality of our faith results in possessions from God that we would never receive if we had not gone through those trials. These are precious in His sight and should be valued greatly. Those who know you will be amazed at the wisdom that comes from your mouth. It is one of those mysteries of the gospel that only those who experience incredible testing and hardship can explain.

God kept the people of Israel enslaved 400 years, but when the time came to free them from the bondage of slavery, they came out with great possessions. These physical possessions symbolize the spiritual possessions we receive when we come out of being enslaved to those things that have hindered us all our lives. These possessions are to be shared with others so that they also can know how they might become free.

What has God freed you from that allows you to share your possessions with others? Share what God has done in your life with someone you work with today. It may be the possession they need most in their life.

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Message 8 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Your Work

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Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/deleted_items/146.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Your Work

I have brought You glory on earth by completing the work You gave Me to do. - (John 17:4)

The Lord has revealed to us that the number one thing we are to do is love the Lord our God with all our heart and to love our neighbor as ourselves. His desire is for us to know Him and the power of His resurrection. These mandates deal with our relationship with Him. The fruit of this relationship must then result in our glorifying Him by completing the work He has given each of us to do. It will become a by-product of this relationship, not an end in itself.

What is the work God has called you to do? Jesus never did anything the Father had not instructed Him to do. He lived in such communion with the Father that He knew when to turn left and when to turn to the right. Is it possible to have such a relationship with our heavenly Father? I think that if it weren't, He would not have given us such an example.

"Call to Me and I will answer you and tell you great and unsearchable things you do not know" (Jer. 33:3). What has He called you to do? Perhaps you are called to be the best CPA in your city or the best advertising executive or the best office worker or assembly-line person in your company. Whatever work He has called you to do, He will use you as His instrument to accomplish something that He has uniquely prepared you to do.

When our life is complete, what a glorious day it will be if we can each say, "I have completed the work You gave me to do." This will have brought great glory to Him.

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Message 9 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Impossible Tasks

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File	king-j/deleted_items/48.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Impossible Tasks

But He answered, "You give them something to eat." - (Mark 6:37)

Has anyone ever asked you to do something that seems totally ridiculous? The very suggestion of their instruction may have brought laughter or even anger for proposing the idea.

I imagine that the disciples may have felt this way when Jesus responded with this comment when they asked him how they were going to feed the 5000 who stayed around to hear him speak. The disciples suggested a logical answer to the problem, "Send the people away so they can go to the surrounding countryside and villages and buy themselves something to eat" (Mk 6:36).

That wasn't the answer Jesus wanted. He saw the need of the people. He had compassion on them. He wanted to solve the problem with a Kingdom response, not logic. He asked them what they had in their hand.

So often what we already have in our hand is what Jesus wants us to use to solve our problems. We must add faith to what we already have in our hand. Then we will see the gospel of the Kingdom manifested to solve problems in a supernatural way. Jesus wanted to meet a need in which God would receive the glory. Sending the people away did not meet the need, nor did it bring glory to the Father.

Do not settle for the gospel of salvation only. Jesus came that we might experience the gospel of the Kingdom in its fullest sense. Our job is to look past our logical reasoning and see how God might want to solve our problem in a supernatural way.

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Message 10 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Our Labor in the Lord

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File	king-j/deleted_items/57.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Our Labor in the Lord

Therefore, my dear brothers, stand firm. Let nothing move you. Always give yourselves fully to the work of the Lord, because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain. - (1 Corinthians 15:58)

There is a paradigm shift going on among a remnant of businesspeople today. That paradigm shift is a focus on using our business and work life as a platform for ministry versus a platform solely for material success. There is a remnant of businesspeople throughout the world today who understand their birthright in the marketplace is to reflect Christ fully in and through their work. It is reflected by a commitment to use their resources and skills to provide a product of excellence with the overall motive to affect people for Jesus Christ. The difference is that these individuals have an overriding ministry objective to their work.

When the apostle Paul tells us to fully work unto the Lord, he does not mean we must be working as missionaries in "full-time Christian effort." He understands that all of life is holy and sacred to God. If our motive is to serve God where we are, then our labor "in the Lord is not in vain."

As you begin your work today, ask God if you are working with the primary motive of reflecting His life and character through your work on this day. Let nothing move you from this motive being central to your activity. The Lord will reflect His power and leading in and through your life when this becomes your primary motive.

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Message 11 of 37

TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- An Encounter With God

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Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/deleted_items/2.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

An Encounter With God

So I was left alone, gazing at this great vision; I had no strength left, my face turned deathly pale and I was helpless. -
(Daniel 10:8)

Daniel received a vision that troubled him greatly. He wanted understanding of this vision. He set himself out to understand the vision by fasting for three weeks. Three days after his three weeks of fasting, a messenger of God appeared to Daniel. The messenger explained that Heaven had heard his prayer from the first day, but the angel was temporarily prevented from coming by the prince of Persia, a demon angel, who sought to thwart God's messenger from coming to Daniel.

There are times in our lives when we must set ourselves to seeking God with all our hearts. It is in these times that we hear from Heaven in ways we may never have experienced before. Daniel's perseverance in prayer was rewarded with a personal encounter with Heaven. However, in order to receive from God, Daniel had to be left alone, his strength removed, and be placed in a helpless condition. When we have no ability in our own strength to move Heaven or the events around us, we are in position to hear from Heaven. It is the acknowledgment of our humanity and our frailness that places us in a position to have a personal encounter with the living God.

Do you need a personal encounter with God today? Do you need God to intervene on your behalf? Seek Him with all your heart. Demonstrate to Him you are serious. Get alone and acknowledge your helpless condition before Him. He will reward you with His presence.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- First Fruits

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Recipients	[jeff.king@enron.com]
File	king-j/deleted_items/74.

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

First Fruits

All the silver and gold and the articles of bronze and iron are sacred to the Lord and must go into His treasury. - (Joshua 6:19)

One of the earliest examples of the practice of giving God the first fruits of the increase was when Joshua and the people entered the Promised Land for the first time. When they crossed the Jordan River, their first battle was Jericho. God set a precedent with this battle by instructing them not to take any spoils from it. Unlike future battles, the fruits from this victory were to go into the treasury as a remembrance of their first victory in the Promised Land. In addition, the city of Jericho was to be a lasting monument to God's faithfulness. God instructed Joshua never to rebuild this city. If they or anyone in the future attempted to rebuild the city, the life of the firstborn would be required. Years later, Ahab attempted to rebuild this city and his firstborn died as a result. God never forgets to enforce His Word.

Is your work a lasting monument to the faithfulness of God in your life? Is it bringing glory to the Father? Are you giving the first fruits from your increase to God? God has encouraged us through this story to give the first fruits of our work to Him so that He will be glorified through our work. This is a tangible way for us to acknowledge that God is the source of all blessing.

***** Author's Note *****

Do you know the 7 Stages of a Call from God? We'd like to make a free audio recording available to you through our website. You may receive the link of this recording by sending a request to 7stages@quicktell.com

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- A Man Who Has God's Favor

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

A Man Who Has God's Favor

"...Let us go with you, because we have heard that God is with you." - (Zechariah 8:23)

Few men of God have become extraordinary people of faith without the influence of mentors. A mentor is one who takes responsibility for the spiritual and, sometimes, physical care of another. It requires a commitment from the teacher and the student.

Elijah mentored Elisha. Elisha became one of the greatest prophets in all the Bible. One of the primary reasons for this was Elisha's hunger. Elisha wanted a double portion of Elijah's spirit. It was this hunger that drove Elisha to be sold out to God's purposes for his life.

I have been privileged to have had many mentors throughout my spiritual life. In each stage of my maturity, God brought new mentors who had unique gifts that the previous mentor did not have. God has given me the hunger to desire a double portion of those positive attributes of my mentors. This desire is sorely missing among many today. I fail to see the hunger among many who could be used greatly in the Kingdom. Instead, they get distracted by the cares of this world. It is an attitude of a la carte versus an attitude of pressing in to the full measure of what God might have for them.

Who are the people of God He has placed in your life? Are you learning from them? Are you seeking a double portion of their anointing? What prevents you from gaining from their wisdom and experience? God may have brought them into your life to prepare you to be a man or woman of God with great anointing. However, there is a time of training and waiting to prove out your own faith. Ask God today if there is someone He would have you mentor or be mentored by.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Knowledge That is Productive

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Knowledge That is Productive

For if you possess these qualities in increasing measure, they will keep you from being ineffective and unproductive in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. - (2 Peter 1:8)

Productivity is a term all businesspeople can relate to. It is the by-product of what we desire from our work. Without productivity, we do not make sales, we do not deliver goods, we do not achieve our goals. There are things in our business lives that can creep in making us unproductive. The same is true in our walk with God.

The apostle Peter tells us that we can become knowledgeable of Jesus but fail to be effective and productive in our relationship with Him. We are a society that has great knowledge, but our comparable scale of productivity from that knowledge is extremely weighted to the knowledge side. The apostle Peter tells us there is a solution to this dilemma.

For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith goodness; and to goodness, knowledge; and to knowledge, self-control; and to self-control, perseverance; and to perseverance, godliness; and to godliness, brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness, love. For if you possess these qualities in increasing measure, they will keep you from being ineffective and unproductive in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ (2 Peter 1:5-8).

Is your Christian experience filled with knowledge, but little power? Is there a staleness in your walk with God? Is there an unrest in your soul? It may be due to a need to develop character that only the Holy Spirit can develop out of an obedient heart. Ask the Lord today to add these qualities to your faith so that you can be productive as a soldier of Jesus Christ.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Horizontal Versus Vertical

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Horizontal Versus Vertical

Glancing this way and that and seeing no one, he killed the Egyptian and hid him in the sand. - (Exodus 2:12)

Moses saw the pain of his people. He saw the bondage and the injustice. His heart was enraged, and he decided he would do something. He would take matters into his own hands. The result was murder. The motive was right, but the action was wrong. He went horizontal instead of vertical with God. The action was wrong. Moses fled to the desert, where God prepared the man who would ultimately be the deliverer of a nation. But it took 40 years of preparation before God determined Moses was ready. He was a professional businessman-a shepherd. It was during the mundane activity of work that God called on him to be a deliverer.

Moses was like a lot of enthusiastic Christian businesspeople who seek to solve a spiritual problem with a fleshly answer. The greatest danger to the Christian businessperson is his greatest strength-his business acumen and expertise to get things done. This self-reliance can become our greatest weakness when it comes to moving in the spiritual realm. We're taught to be problem solvers. But, like Moses, if our enthusiasm and passion are not harnessed by the power of the Holy Spirit, we will fail miserably. Peter had to learn this lesson too. His enthusiasm got him into a lot of trouble. But God was patient, just as He is patient with each of us. Sometimes He must put us in the desert for a time in order to season us so that Christ is allowed to reign supreme in the process.

Before you act, pray and seek the mind of Christ until you know it is God behind the action. Check it out with others. You may save yourself a trip to the desert.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Godly Rewards

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Godly Rewards

You have said, "It is futile to serve God. What did we gain by carrying out His requirements and going about like mourners before the Lord Almighty? But now we call the arrogant blessed. Certainly the evildoers prosper, and even those who challenge God escape." - (Malachi 3:14-15)

Have you ever felt that serving God had little reward and the ungodly seemed actually to be more blessed than you? This is what the people of God felt. God heard their cry and responded through the prophet Malachi to explain God's view on this matter.

Then those who feared the Lord talked with each other, and the Lord listened and heard. A scroll of remembrance was written in His presence concerning those who feared the Lord and honored His name. "They will be Mine," says the Lord Almighty, "in the day when I make up My treasured possession. I will spare them, just as in compassion a man spares his son who serves him. And you will again see the distinction between the righteous and the wicked, between those who serve God and those who do not" (Malachi 3:16-18).

Notice that after the people complained about this, they began to talk to each other, and the Lord listened and heard. God had been taking note of those who were serving Him and honoring Him. There is a day coming in which God will honor His "treasured possessions." We will see that there is a distinction between the righteous and the wicked on that day when "the sun of righteousness will rise with healing in its wings. And you will go out and leap like calves released from the stall" (Mal. 4:2). What a beautiful picture of what we will feel like on that day.

Faithful obedience is rewarded by God. It often requires patience, suffering, and perseverance. Be of good cheer; He will reward you if you faint not.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Loose Your Donkey

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Loose Your Donkey

..."Go to the village ahead of you, and at once you will find a donkey tied there, with her colt by her. Untie them and bring them to Me. If anyone says anything to you, tell him that the Lord needs them...." - (Matthew 21:2-3)

A donkey was an animal of commerce in Jesus' day. It was used to carry great burdens of goods from place to place and he was known as the "beast of the burden." This donkey no doubt was owned by a village businessperson. But Jesus told His disciples to fetch the donkey for "He had need of it." This donkey played an important part in Jesus' triumphal entry into Jerusalem. It was a day that was the culmination of three years of ministry. Jesus chose to use a vehicle of commerce to bring Him into His most important public display.

We are entering a time in our own history in which God is saying to businesspeople, "Loose your donkey for My purposes. I have need of it." God is preparing His Church to be a vessel for ushering in a great harvest of souls. He is preparing His remnant of businesspeople, who are like a tribe within the Church, to be a major force in this great harvest.

"He will tether his donkey to a vine, his colt to the choicest branch; he will wash his garments in wine, his robes in the blood of grapes. His eyes will be darker than wine, his teeth whiter than milk" (Gen. 49:11-12). Is your donkey tied to the living Vine, the choicest branch of Jesus Himself? When we are tied to the living Vine, designed for His use, we will be useful in God's Kingdom. Jesus wants to free us from the bondage of business slavery; He wants us to walk in freedom so that others may see God's grace flowing through us and our place in the business world. Is your donkey available for His use?

Today, ask Jesus to allow the Vine to flow through you in every area of your life.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Unprofitable Anger

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Unprofitable Anger

Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit, for anger resides in the lap of fools. - (Ecclesiastes 7:9)

Every day of our lives we are placed in situations that engage us with other people, whether it is in the office, our homes, or in public places. Do you recall the last time someone cut you off in traffic, or you were forced to wait in line because someone up front got held up? Perhaps your employer did something that was downright unfair. Anger can result from many circumstances.

A friend once told me that anger is like warning lights on the front of your car dashboard. They signal that there is something going on under the hood, and we should take a look to examine the source of the problem. Anger can be traced to a few sources. First, when we lose control of a circumstance that we have placed certain expectations on and those expectations do not result in our desired outcome, we are tempted to get angry. The source of this type of anger is both fear and protection of personal rights. You see, when we believe we have a right to something, we have not given the Lord permission to allow an outcome different from what we want. If an outcome is different from our expectations, this may stimulate fear.

For instance, if a vendor failed to deliver an important job on time due to something out of his control, you may respond out of anger. Please know that the source of your anger is the fear of what might happen to you or what this might say about your abilities to manage a project. You no longer are in control of the circumstance and this creates fear in you.

The next time you get angry ask the Lord what is the source of that anger? Did the Lord allow that failure to let you see what is "under your hood"? God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of love, power, and a sound mind (see 2 Tim. 1:7). Give up your rights to expectations that God never gave you. You will find a new freedom in Christ you never knew you could have.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Fruitful Suffering

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Fruitful Suffering

..."It is because God has made me fruitful in the land of my suffering." - (Genesis 41:52)

Joseph named his second son Ephraim. Ephraim was given to him after he had been delivered from his suffering of 13 years. Joseph said that he named him this because God had made him fruitful in the land of his suffering. Ephraim means "twice fruitful."

Joseph was fruitful in two instances. He was fruitful during his time of adversity and in his prosperity. When God brings us into a time of suffering, it can be a fruitful time. It's rare for us to see the fruit during the suffering period. But know that the roots are going deep into the spiritual soil of our soul because of our pressing in to God during our time of suffering. This is producing a work in our character that cannot be seen until it finishes the process. Such was the case for Joseph.

It was not until several years after such a time of suffering that I began to see the fruit of the trials that the Lord allowed me to experience. How grateful I am to understand some of the "why" that has led to a new life in Him that I would never have had without this period.

Samson had great anointing but lacked character. We see many today who have great anointing yet lack character. But God is raising up Josephs who not only have great anointing for these days but also great character. Suffering produces character.

If you find yourself in a time of suffering, now is the time to press into God. Let your roots grow deeper. Whenever there is a famine, tree roots are forced to drive deeper into the soil to find water. These times are designed to create such a deep-rooted faith that our natures will be changed forever.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Ability Versus Availability

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Ability Versus Availability

His pleasure is not in the strength of the horse, nor His delight in the legs of a man; the Lord delights in those who fear Him, who put their hope in His unfailing love. - (Psalms 147:10-11)

Do you ever feel so skilled in what you do that you require little help from others? Perhaps you may feel that you are more skilled than any other in your field. Does God need your skills and abilities in order to accomplish His purposes on this earth? The answer is NO.

One thing God does not need is our skills and abilities. However, He does give us the privilege to exercise our gifts and abilities for His service. That service may be as a computer technician, a secretary, an ironworker, or even a lawyer. God calls each of us to our vocations to work unto Him. To believe that He needs our skills to accomplish His mission on earth would be to lower our understanding of an all-encompassing and all-powerful God. The psalmist tells us that His pleasure is not in our strength and ability, but His pleasure is in the attitude of the heart. It is what we find in the heart that helps determine whether ability is translated into availability. You see, God is looking to and fro throughout the earth for a man or woman who is fully committed to Him. A man or woman who is committed to fearing the Lord and placing his hope in His unfailing love is the person God seeks to support. "For the eyes of the Lord range throughout the earth to strengthen those whose hearts are fully committed to Him" (2 Chron. 16:9a). When our agenda becomes His agenda, we can expect God to fully support all that we do.

If we want to see our skills and abilities multiplied a hundredfold, then we must make them completely available to His service. Where are the opportunities in which God is calling you to be available to Him? Next time someone asks you to be involved in some activity, before you say yea or nay, make sure you check in with the Master of our decisions to ensure that your gifts and talents are being used as He desires.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Seeing a Greater Purpose in

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Seeing a Greater Purpose in Adversity

But Paul shouted, "Don't harm yourself! We are all here!" - (Acts 16:28)

Paul and Silas had just been thrown into prison. An earthquake erupted and the jail cell was opened. It's Paul and Silas' opportunity. "Deliverance! Praise God!" might be the appropriate response. But this is not what Paul and Silas did. In fact, rather than leave, they sat quietly in their cell area. The guard, in fear of his life, knew that it would be automatic death if prisoners escaped. Paul and Silas did not leave because they saw a higher purpose for which they were in prison. They were not looking at their circumstance; they were much more concerned about the unsaved guard. The story goes on to explain how Paul and Silas went home with the guard and his family. Not only did the guard get saved, but his entire household as well.

What a lesson this is for us. How often we are so busy looking for deliverance from our circumstance that we miss God completely. God is looking to do miracles in our circumstances if we will only look for them. Sometimes as businesspeople we become so obsessed with our goals we miss the process that God involves us in, which may be where the miracle lies. What if that bill collector who has been hounding you is unsaved and he is there for you to speak to? What if a problem account has arisen due to something God is doing beyond what you might see at this time? Our adverse situations can often be the door of spiritual opportunity for those who need it.

I saw this personally when God allowed me to go through a number of adversities. It took some time, but I saw some great miracles as a result of those adversities. When God said that "all things work together for good for those who are called

according to His purposes" (see Rom. 8:28), He meant all things. It is up to us to find the "work together for good" part by being faithful to the process. In the next adversity you face, tune your spiritual antennae and ask God for discernment to see the real purpose for the adversity.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Sweating Outcomes

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Sweating Outcomes

In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for food to eat-for He grants sleep to those He loves. - (Psalms 127:2)

Coming into the Promised Land in business will change the way you and I view our work. No longer will we see getting up early and staying up late as God's way. Living in the Promised Land in business means we know that God is the source of our provision and that our work is an act of worship to Him. Provision is a by-product, not an end in itself. Work is no longer something that must be sweated and toiled upon to make ends meet. "Could this really be true?" you might be saying. God has made it clear that obedience is the assurance of provision. Whenever we go beyond the normal workday due to fear of non-provision, we are operating in unbelief. We are saying that it is up to us to make things happen. Sure, there are times when we work longer hours due to a deadline, but we must be sure the motive is not out of fear of loss or fear of non-provision. If we are obedient to what God has called us to, He will provide our every need. This can be a hard lesson for goal-oriented businesspeople.

I recall coming into this understanding. I had been a workaholic. Long hours were common. Then God shook up my world and I was challenged by a friend to examine my motives for working long hours. I realized the source of those long hours was fear. Once I came into this understanding, I refused to work long hours even though the natural man would tell me I'd

never make things happen if I worked a normal work week. Again, this reasoning is based on a lack of faith. If we are obedient to what God has called each of us to, we will not lack. At times it may be less than what we might like; at other times it may be more than we deserve. These are God's ways.

The Bible tells us to come out of Babylon. Babylon is a system of work and philosophy that is contrary to God's ways. Are you operating in any aspect of work from a Babylonian value system? Ask the Lord to reveal this to you. Begin to walk in the freedom He has given us in our work life.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- A New Breed of Businesspeople

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

A New Breed of Businesspeople

Speak to Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, to Joshua son of Jehozadak, the high priest, and to the remnant of the people.... - (Haggai 2:2)

Zerubbabel was the governor of Judah 60 years after the great temple built by Solomon had been destroyed. The temple lay in ruins, and the Lord spoke to the prophet Haggai, "Is it a time for you yourselves to be living in your paneled houses, while this house remains a ruin?" (Hag. 1:4) God was calling for a remnant of His people to come out of their comfort zones and restore the glory of God's house.

God is doing this same thing today among Christian businesspeople throughout the world. He is raising up a remnant of businesspeople who are being handpicked to use their resources, skills, and experience to affect nations that have not heard the message of Jesus Christ. The only way they can hear is by commerce being brought into their nation through

Christian businesspeople, because these are closed regions to normal missionary efforts.

"But now be strong, O Zerubbabel," declares the Lord. "Be strong, O Joshua son of Jehozadak, the high priest. Be strong, all you people of the land," declares the Lord, "and work. For I am with you," declares the Lord Almighty. "This is what I covenanted with you when you came out of Egypt. And My Spirit remains among you. Do not fear" (Haggai 2:4-5).

The remnant of businesspeople God is calling today understand that they have to come out of Egypt from their past business life. Egypt signifies the way of the world. It represents sweat and toil. It is the flesh. This new way is exemplified by a pioneer spirit. God knows we need to have courage in order to move in this realm. Also, God assures us that His Spirit is with anyone who seeks to live in the realm of supernatural faith.

Are you one of these remnants He has handpicked in these days? Has He called you out of Egypt in order to do extraordinary things in your life for His Kingdom? Ask God to show you how He wants to use you in the marketplace this year. Then act and "be strong, all you people of the land."

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- The Dangers of Overcontrol

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

The Dangers of Overcontrol

For rebellion is like the sin of divination, and arrogance like the evil of idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the Lord, He has rejected you as king. - (1 Samuel 15:23)

A friend of mine who is a jet pilot once told me that whenever a jet goes out of control and begins to spin, the only thing to do is totally take your hands off the controls and the plane will right itself. This goes against our natural inclination to

control and manipulate in order to bring things back under control. It is scary to be out of control. Or is it?

Saul was a man out of control. He was losing control of his kingdom to David. He was losing the favor of God and the people. It began as compromises. Eventually he was given a final test to obey the voice of God fully. He was instructed to kill the Amalekites completely; but he failed to follow through. The prophet Samuel delivered a hard word to King Saul, "Because you have rejected the word of the Lord, He has rejected you as king" (see 1 Sam. 15:26). Saul obeyed partially, but not fully. It was partial obedience that led to his removal as king of Israel and his calling from God. But why did Saul do such a thing? "I was afraid of the people and so I gave in to them" (1 Sam. 15:24b). Saul's fear and insecurity made him more afraid of the people and what they thought than of God. At the core of Saul's disobedience was fear of losing control. That fear of losing control led to partial obedience and the loss of his reign as king.

How many of us are in danger of losing God's blessing due to partial obedience? How many of us have such a need to control people and circumstances that we fail to fully walk in obedience to God's voice in our lives? Saul provides a great lesson for us as businesspeople. The need to overcontrol things around us can prevent us from receiving all that God has for us. Today, take an inventory of your control quotient.

Ask God if you are being fully obedient to what He has called you to do this day, and avoid being put on the shelf for disobedience. "To obey is better than sacrifice, and to heed is better than the fat of rams" (1 Sam. 15:22b).

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Sacrificing at What Cost

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Sacrificing at What Cost

..."I will not sacrifice to the Lord my God burnt offerings that cost me nothing." - (2 Samuel 24:24)

One day I was having lunch with a man who had a certain amount of notoriety in his life. After a time of getting to know each other, he said, "How can I help you?" Those words surprised me coming from a man who obviously already had many requirements on his time. My first thought was that I was impressed with the individual. My next thought was to wonder whether it was a genuine offer or just an effort to impress me with his humility and Christian piety. I have since discovered he was sincere.

This encounter reminded me that each of us must be willing to give to others without a motive to get anything in return. It is simply an act of serving others. Jesus said that we must consider others more important than ourselves. When is the last time you did something for another without a motive of getting anything in return?

When King David came to offer a sacrifice and pray for the removal of a plague on Israel, he was given the opportunity to make the sacrifice without the cost of purchasing the sacrificial animals.

But the king replied to Araunah, "No, I insist on paying you for it. I will not sacrifice to the Lord my God burnt offerings that cost me nothing." So David bought the threshing floor and the oxen and paid fifty shekels of silver for them. David built an altar to the Lord there and sacrificed burnt offerings and fellowship offerings. Then the Lord answered prayer in behalf of the land, and the plague on Israel was stopped (2 Samuel 24:24-25).

David, understanding the principle of giving, said he could not offer anything to God that did not cost him something. Otherwise, it was not a sacrificial gift.

When is the last time you sacrificed for another that it cost you something with no expectation of getting anything in return? We can all give something to others, such as our time, our money, or our expertise. This is real Christianity that models the Spirit of Christ. The next time you meet with someone, why not consider how you might be a blessing to that person. Why not ask, "How can I help you?"

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- The Famine That Leads to Freedom

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

The Famine That Leads to Freedom

Go down there and buy some for us, so that we may live and not die. - (Genesis 42:2)

F. B. Meyer in his book, *The Life of Joseph*, describes a time in the life of the 12 sons of Jacob in which they were driven from their lives of self-satisfaction to an unlikely place to save their lives. Many years earlier they had thrown their youngest brother into a pit, then sold him into slavery. Thirteen years later he became the second most powerful person in Egypt. Now the world was experiencing a famine, and Joseph controlled all the stored grain of Egypt.

As long as the hills were green and the pastures clothed with flocks, as long as the valleys were covered over with corn and rang with the songs of reapers, Reuben, Simeon, and the rest of them would have been unconcerned and content. But when the mighty famine came, the hearts of these men were opened to conviction. Their carnal security was shattered. They were being prepared for certain spiritual experiences they would never have dreamed. And they were being prepared for the meeting with Joseph. This is how God deals with us; He breaks up our nest, He loosens our roots, He sends a mighty famine that cuts away the whole staff of bread. Then, at such times, weary, worn, and sad, we are prepared to confess our sins and receive the words of Christ when He says, "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Mt. 11:28).

A missionary once said, "There is a place where we will all be obedient." Joseph was a type of Christ in the Old Testament. The famine was an event designed to bring the brothers to repentance and a saving knowledge, physically and spiritually. It created the circumstances that led to freedom for these men. For they had been in bondage to a wicked crime against their brother for many years. It was the forgiveness from Joseph that led to that freedom.

Is your life passing through a time of famine? Are your supplies limited? Is God leading you into directions that you would not normally seek? Perhaps this is God's hand creating circumstances for His purposes. Now is the time to look attentively as He directs you to unlikely sources.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Paneled Houses

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Paneled Houses

"Is it a time for you yourselves to be living in your paneled houses, while this house remains a ruin?" - (Haggai 1:4)

There is a crisis of grand proportions in the spiritual house of God today. The moral fiber of our world has eroded. Greed, idolatry, and pleasure are the gods of our day. And it is no different in the Body of Christ.

The prophet Haggai wrote about a people who had lost concern for the need to build God's house because they were so focused on their own worldly needs. It is a dangerous place to get with God. When our world begins to focus around increasing our pleasure, building bigger and better homes, and failing to make what is important to God important in our own lives, this should be a warning to us.

Jesus entered the temple area and drove out all who were buying and selling there. He overturned the tables of the money changers and the benches of those selling doves. "It is written," He said to them, " 'My house will be called a house of prayer,' but you are making it a 'den of robbers' " (Matthew. 21:12-13).

Jesus came into Jerusalem and found the businesspeople buying and selling in the temple. As far as they knew, this was an acceptable practice in their day. Their fathers did it, and now they were doing it. It was business as usual. Jesus got angry, turned over the tables, and said that His house was a house of prayer. He found the businesspeople of the day seeing His house as a place for profit, not prayer. They had stepped into a place of complacency that was not acceptable to the Lord. When we begin to blend in with the moral condition of an ungodly world, we begin losing God's perspective on life.

It is easy to begin blending in with our culture and to accept what is being modeled by the ungodly. God called us to be salt in a world that needs much salt. "You are the salt of the earth. But if the salt loses its saltiness, how can it be made salty again? It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled by men" (Mt. 5:13). Each of us must ask ourselves if we have lost our salt. Are we having an impact on our world? Or is our world having an impact on us? Ask God to give you a vision for how you can be salt to your world today.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Seeing the Works of God

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Seeing the Works of God

Others went out on the sea in ships; they were merchants on the mighty waters. They saw the works of the Lord.... - (Psalms 107:23-24)

When you were a child, perhaps you may have gone to the ocean for a vacation. I recall wading out until the waves began crashing on my knees. As long as I could stand firm, the waves were of no concern to me. However, as I moved farther and farther into the ocean, I had less control over my ability to stand. Sometimes the current was so strong it moved me down the beach, and I even lost my bearings at times. But I have never gone so far into the ocean that I was not able to control the situation.

Sometimes God takes us into such deep waters that we lose control of the situation, and we have no choice but to fully trust in His care for us. This is doing business in great waters. It is in these great waters that we see the works of God.

The Scriptures tell us that the disciples testified of what they saw and heard. It was the power behind the gospel, not the words themselves, that changed the world. The power wasn't seen until circumstances got to the point that there were no alternatives but God. Sometimes God has to take us into the deep water in order to give us the privilege to see His works.

Sometimes God takes us into the deep waters of life for an extended time. Joseph was taken into deep waters of adversity for 17 years. Rejection by his brothers, enslavement to Pharaoh, and imprisonment were the deep waters for Joseph. During those deep waters, he experienced dreams, a special anointing of his gifts to administrate, and great wisdom beyond his years. The deep water was preparation for a task that was so great he never could have imagined it. He was to see God's works more clearly than anyone in his generation. God had too much at stake for a 30-year-old to mess it up. So, God took Joseph through the deep waters of preparation to ensure that he would survive what he was about to face. Pride normally engulfs such young servants who have such access to power at such a young age.

If God chooses to take us into deep waters, it is for a reason. The greater the calling, the deeper the water. Trust in His knowledge that your deep waters are preparation to see the works of God in your life.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Coming Out of Babylon

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Coming Out of Babylon

..."Come out of her, My people, so that you will not share in her sins, sso that you will not receive any of her plagues; for her sins are piled up to heaven, and God has remembered her crimes." - (Revelation 18:4)

There is a day when God is going to judge the system of Babylon around the world. What is Babylon? Babylon is a system of doing business. The stronghold of the marketplace is mammon and pride. Dependence on money and misplaced trust are at the core of a Babylonian philosophy of life. Revelation 18 describes a time when God will judge this Babylonian system. It is the one place that we see a system destroyed in one day, even one hour. I do not believe Babylon is a particular city, but a world system. "Therefore in one day her plagues will overtake her" (Rev. 18:8a). "Woe! Woe, O great city, O Babylon, city of power! In one hour your doom has come!" (Rev. 18:10b).

As Christian businesspeople we are called to acknowledge the signs of the times. When the Soviet Union fell, many knew it was going to happen because they could recognize the signs of the times. God has a way of shaking things up. These shakings force us to determine who and what we will place our trust in. God says that we are to "Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind" (Mt. 22:37).

Are you still living in Babylon in the way you do business? If so, expect to share in the sins of Babylon when God decides to judge her. Ask God to show you where you might be operating in a "Babylonian" system of work.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- When God Seems Far Away

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

When God Seems Far Away

Why, O Lord, do You stand far off? Why do You hide Yourself in times of trouble? - (Psalms 10:1)

One of the great mysteries of God is His ways. Some of His ways almost appear to bring us into the most difficult places, as if He were indifferent to our circumstances. It would appear that He is turning His head from our sorrows. These events in our lives have a particular objective to perform for us. That objective is to bring us to the end of ourselves that we might discover the treasure of darkness. "Yet when I hoped for good, evil came; when I looked for light, then came darkness" (Job 30:26).

When we are taken into these dark periods, we begin to see light that we never knew existed. Our sensitivities become heightened and our ability to see through spiritual eyes is illuminated. Unless we are taken into these times, our souls never develop any depth of character. We do not gain wisdom, only knowledge. Knowledge is gained through understanding; wisdom is gained through the experience of darkness.

After we go through these periods, we discover that God was, in fact, with us throughout the entire time. It does not feel or appear that He is there when we are in the midst of the dark periods. However, He is there walking with us. He has told us countless times that He will never leave us. However, when we are in those dark periods, it does not feel like He is there because He does not rescue us from the circumstances. He does this for our benefit in order that we might become more like Jesus. Jesus learned obedience from the things He suffered (see Heb. 5:8). What does that say about how you and I will learn obedience? Embrace the dark times and gain the wisdom that God intends for you from these times.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- The Skillful Worker

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

The Skillful Worker

Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will serve before kings; he will not serve before obscure men. - (Proverbs 22:29)

The Lord has called each of us to be excellent in what we do. Those whom God used in the Kingdom as marketplace ministers were skilled and exemplified excellence in their field. Not only were these men skilled, they were filled with God's Spirit.

Then the Lord said to Moses, "See, I have chosen Bezalel son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah, and I have filled him with the Spirit of God, with skill, ability and knowledge in all kinds of crafts-to make artistic designs for work in gold, silver and bronze, to cut and set stones, to work in wood, and to engage in all kinds of craftsmanship" (Exodus 31:1-5).

Consider Hiram, the master craftsman of bronze in whom Solomon entrusted much of the temple designs. He was a true master craftsman (see 1 Kings 7:14).

Consider Joseph, whose skill as an administrator was known throughout Egypt and the world. Consider Daniel, who served his king with great skill and integrity. The list could go on-David, Nehemiah, Aquilla and Priscilla.

I recall the first issue of an international publication we began. It was common to hear the comment, "It doesn't even look like a Christian magazine." They were saying the quality and excellence exceeded what they equated to Christian work. What a shame. Has inferior quality become synonymous with Christian work?

May we strive for excellence in all that we do for the Master of the universe.

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for men, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving (Colossians 3:23-24).

***** Author's Note *****

How can you experience God in your work? Why do most of us tend to segment our spiritual life from our work life? Can I really know God's will for my life? How can I make decisions that will be blessed by God? Why do most Christians in the workplace live a defeated life? Join Os and Angie Hillman for the Called to the Workplace one day workshop and find these answers along with many more October 26,27 in Columbia, SC
<http://sda.goshen.net/cgi-bin/redirect.cgi?AD=marketplace01>

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Standing in the Gap

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Standing in the Gap

I looked for a man among them who would build up the wall and stand before Me in the gap on behalf of the land so I would not have to destroy it, but I found none. - (Ezekiel 22:30)

The people of Israel fell into sin when they worshiped the golden calf. It would not be the last time God's people would fall into idol worship. They had forgotten the great things God had done for them. This angered God so much that He was going to destroy the whole nation. Only one thing changed God's mind in the matter-Moses. Psalm 106:23 says, "...had not Moses, His chosen one, stood in the breach before Him to keep His wrath from destroying them." Moses was a man willing to stand in the gap, sacrificially, for those who were not deserving of such sacrifice. This sacrificial love by Moses is called for among His people today.

The prophet Ezekiel described another situation in which God's people fell into sin. God was ready to destroy the nation when He spoke to Ezekiel, asking him if there is a man willing to stand in the gap so that God would not have to destroy His people.

Judah was a man who stood in the gap on behalf of his younger brother Benjamin. Joseph held his brother Simeon hostage as insurance that the other brothers would bring Benjamin to Egypt. Judah had a long history of a me-focused life, but in this instance he came forward to stand in the gap for his younger brother. He responded to the anguish of his father, Jacob, by personally guaranteeing the safe return of both Simeon and Benjamin. Judah's sacrifice was rewarded (see Gen. 42-43).

Just as Christ did, we are to be those who will stand in the gap on behalf of others who are not aware of their own vulnerable condition. It is a proactive sacrificial position. Who is God calling you to stand in the gap for? Perhaps it is a mate; perhaps it is a business associate who has not come to know the Savior; perhaps it is a wayward child. Are you willing to become the sacrificial offering to God to change His plans of judgment because of your willingness to stand in their place? This is a hard teaching. This is what Jesus did for each of us. When we stand in the place of another, God moves because of our willingness to stand on their behalf. If we don't, His plans will go forward because He is a righteous and holy God who will honor His own word, even if it means destruction. Are you willing to stand in the breach of the wall for someone today? Perhaps you are the only person who will stand on someone's behalf.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Passing the Tests

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Passing the Tests

The Lord has torn the kingdom out of your hands and given it to one of your neighbors-to David. - (1 Samuel 28:17)

When God anoints a person, a pattern of testing appears to take place at specific times in the leader's life. God often takes each leader through four major tests to determine if that person will achieve God's ultimate call on his or her life. The person's response to these tests is the deciding factor in whether they can advance to the next level of responsibility in God's Kingdom.

Control-Control is one of the first tests. Saul spent most of his time as king trying to prevent others from getting what he had. Saul never got to the place with God in which he was a grateful recipient of God's goodness to him. Saul was a religious controller. This control led to disobedience and ultimately being rejected by God because Saul no longer was a vessel God could use.

Bitterness-Every major character in the Bible was hurt by another person at one time or another. Jesus was hurt deeply when Judas, a trusted follower, betrayed Him. Despite knowing this was going to happen, Jesus responded by washing Judas' feet. Every anointed leader will have a Judas experience at one time or another. God watches us to see how we will respond to this test. Will we take up an offense? Will we retaliate? It is one of the most difficult tests to pass.

Power-Power is the opposite of servanthood. Jesus had all authority in Heaven and earth, so satan tempted Jesus at the top of the mountain to use His power to remove Himself from a difficult circumstance. How will we use the power and influence God has entrusted to us? Do we seek to gain more power? There is a common phrase in the investment community, "He who has the gold rules." Jesus modeled the opposite. He was the ultimate servant leader.

Greed-This is a difficult one. Money has the ability to have great influence for either good or bad. When it is a focus in our life, it becomes a tool of destruction. When it is a by-product, it can become a great blessing. Many leaders started out well-only to be derailed once prosperity became a part of their life. There are thousands who can blossom spiritually in adversity; only a few can thrive spiritually under prosperity.

As leaders, we must be aware when we are being tested. You can be confident that each one of these tests will be thrown your way if God calls you for His purposes. Will you pass these tests? Ask for God's grace today to walk through these tests victoriously.

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Weapons of Warfare

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Weapons of Warfare

Beat your plowshares into swords and your pruning hooks into spears. - (Joel 3:10)

In this third chapter of Joel, we hear the prophet describe a time yet to come. It will be a time of great harvest on the earth, and this verse describes the catalyst. A plowshare is an agricultural instrument used to till the soil. At this point in history, it was a tool that spoke of one's vocation. However, the prophet was speaking of a time yet to come. The prophet described the plowshare as an instrument that will be turned into a sword. The sword is often used in the Bible to describe God's Word. The only way a plowshare can be turned into a sword is for it to go through extreme heat, and then the blacksmith must beat that plowshare into shape. Heat and punishment of the metal turns that plowshare into an instrument of battle. God must do this in each of our lives in order for us to be useable as a worthy sword. We are all in a battle-a spiritual battle. Paul describes our battle as one against the principalities of the unseen world. I believe God is going to raise up many in the marketplace to use their plowshare as a weapon of righteousness in these last days. That weapon won't be used for destruction, but as a weapon of love. That weapon of love will yield a great harvest in our lifetime. But this is only part of the story.

God is also going to turn our pruning hooks into spears. A pruning hook is used in two ways. First, it is used to prune a tree for greater growth and productivity. It is also used to cut the fruit from taller trees in which one cannot reach the fruit. This fruit from our vocation is going to be cast forth like a spear, but even more as seed planted to bring the harvest of which Joel speaks. Fruit from our business life is often the financial rewards generated. God wants to use our finances and everything else for His purposes. We must use our vocations and the fruit that comes from them as seed to bring the great harvest that God is planning.

How are you using your plowshare and your pruning hook for God's glory today? Ask God to show you how He wants to use your skills, resources, and relationships to prepare for the great harvest He has planned.

***** Author's Note *****

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Placing Trust in Our Strength

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Placing Trust in Our Strength

So the Lord sent a plague on Israel, and seventy thousand men of Israel fell dead. - (1 Chronicles 21:14)

When was the last time your overconfidence cost the lives of 70,000 men? That is exactly what happened to David. David made what might appear to be an innocent request of his general, Joab. But the minute Joab heard the request, he cringed. He knew David was in big trouble for this one. You see, to number the troops was a great sin in Israel because it was against the law. Why? Because it demonstrated that you were placing more trust in numbers than in the living God. David displayed enough pride to cost the lives of 70,000 fighting men. God gave him three choices of punishment for his sin. A plague was the one he chose, and it resulted in the loss of 70,000.

Throughout Israel's history, God set the stage for battles to be won, miracles to take place, and people to exercise faith. The stage was always set so that man could not take credit for what God did. Consider Gideon who was only allowed 300 men to fight an army of 100,000. Consider Jehoshaphat, who had to lead his army with his singers. God defeated the enemy. Consider Joshua, who was told simply to walk around Jericho seven times, and they would get victory. God did things in some very unconventional ways!

How does this relate to you and me as businesspeople? Well, the minute you and I place more trust in our abilities than in God, we are guilty of numbering the troops. How does He punish us? Sometimes it's through letting a deal go sour. Sometimes it's through problems with a client or vendor. Sometimes situations just blow up in our face. Other times, He lets us go on for a long time doing our own thing, but eventually He deals with it.

The lesson here is to learn daily and complete dependence on God. Use your gifts and abilities through the power of the Holy Spirit. Ask Him daily for direction and wisdom. His ways won't always line up with conventional wisdom. When we begin depending on our abilities only, God has a responsibility to make known to us who is the giver of the blessings.

***** Author's Note *****

What are the hindrances that keep you and I from living fully for Christ? What motivates us to destructive behavior? How can I rid myself of bad habits? Read a feature article published by Money Matters newsletter from Christian Financial Concepts (Now Crown Ministries) on Os Hillman's personal Testimony regarding the influence of spiritual strongholds. Request the free article by sending an email to strongholds@quicktell.com

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TGIF Marketplace Meditation -- Four Attributes of a Life God

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

Four Attributes of a Life God Blesses

So this is what the Sovereign Lord says: "See, I lay a stone in Zion, a tested stone, a precious cornerstone for a sure foundation; the one who trusts will never be dismayed." - (Isaiah 28:16)

Whenever God calls us into a consecrated life, it is made up of four distinct stages. Christ often compared this process to building a house. First, we must prepare to build by laying a foundation. That foundation is none other than Jesus Christ Himself. Any foundation other than Christ will not stand.

Second, as we enter a walk of faith with God, He allows each of us to experience trials, testings, miracles, and challenges in life that are designed to provide "faith experiences" that demonstrate tangible evidences of His work in our life: Moses' burning-bush experience, Peter's walk on the water, Joshua's parting of the Jordan River. These experiences built the faith of these people. The depth and width of our calling is directly proportional to the faith experiences He allows in each of our lives. If God plans an international ministry with you, chances are you will experience a higher degree of faith experiences compared to another. The reason is, you will need to look on these to ensure your calling and provide testimony to His work in your life.

The third stage deals with motives. "All a man's ways seem innocent to him, but motives are weighed by the Lord" (Prov. 16:2). What is the motive behind my actions? Is it only financial accumulation? Is it to gain control? Is it to create independence? The primary motive must be God's leading you to take such an action-it must be obedience. These other factors must be by-products of the decision.

Finally, we are prepared to take action. Here we must ask, "Do we have the skill, quality, and ability to enter into this activity?" So often we have not trained ourselves adequately to be successful in our endeavor. You would never want someone working on your teeth who had not been trained and certified as a dentist.

Before you begin your next project, ask yourself these four questions. What is the foundation this project is based on? What experiences has God demonstrated in my life that indicate His involvement? What is my motive for entering this activity? Do I have the skill, quality, and ability to accomplish the task? Answering these questions will tell you whether God will bless your activity.

***** Author's Note *****

Get your year started right. Read Os Hillman's article, Planning and Decision Making: A Biblical Perspective. To receive this free article send name, address, city state, zip to planning@quicktell.com

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T O D A Y G O D I S F I R S T Marketplace Meditations by Os Hillman

The Value of Words

And do not swear by your head, for you cannot make even one hair white or black. Simply let your "Yes" be "Yes," and your "No," "No"; anything beyond this comes from the evil one. - (Matthew 5:36-37)

Imagine for a moment that you are living in Jesus' time. It is before Jesus has begun His public ministry. He is a carpenter in your local town of Nazareth. You have asked Jesus to make a table for you. You're on a deadline and you must have it in a week. You agree on the price of for the table and the date of one week for completion. A week later you arrive to pick up the table. You lay your money down on the table and Jesus says, "Mr. Johnson, I am sorry but the table is not ready. I ran into complications. Also, I can no longer honor the price I gave you. It is now instead of ."

Two years later you hear about this same Jesus who is preaching to the local townspeople. How are you going to view this Jesus? You probably won't give much credence to His message because of your personal experience. Our lives have an ability to reinforce the message we stand for, or they can violate it and make it totally ineffective. This literally happens all over the world in different settings with Christian businesspeople. Our message becomes ineffective because we have not done what we said.

I know people who, when they tell me they plan to do something, I can expect them to follow through about 50 percent of the time. I am sure you have had the same experience. Words and commitments are made with little meaning behind those words. However, I know others who will follow through almost every time. The only time they don't is when something falls outside their control. I quickly learn whose words have substance behind them.

There are times when we are unable to perform or deliver what we promised due to outside influences. The key to turning these potentially negative circumstances into a witness for Christ is communication. If we are unable to pay a bill on time, we must communicate with those we owe and make a good faith effort to resolve it within our means. In these cases, God's purposes are being performed as well if we seek to do the right thing.

Do your words mean anything to those who hear them? Do you make commitments and fail to follow through on them? What would others say about how you follow through? Ask the Lord today to show you how you are doing in this area. You might even want to ask three people who are the closest to you how you fare in this area.

***** Author's Note *****

How do you develop plans? Is the pro and con method of decision making biblical? What does the bible say about how to plan? Read Os Hillman's free article Planning & Decisionmaking: A Biblical Approach. To receive a free article via email, send your name, address, city, state zip to planning@quicktell.com

Published and distributed by Crosswalk.com, this daily devotional is written by Os Hillman (os@marketplaceleaders.org). Os is president of Marketplace Leaders, an Atlanta based ministry teaching Biblical principles for career and business success. He offers a FREE newsletter and other resources at: <http://www.marketplaceleaders.org>

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